way it was beginning to turn a small profit in the East India Company's account into a large loss, Auckland was under strict instructions from London to train up in Afghanistan an efficient Afghan national army for Shah Shuja. This would allow the Company to pull back its troops to India while leaving Shuja secure and able to defend himself. 'I have earnestly impressed it upon Macnaghten that every exertion must be made to consolidate the power of Shah Shooja,' wrote the Governor General, 'to give efficiency to his army and popularity to his government [as] our regular troops cannot remain there beyond the present season . . .'[63] Auckland was equally frank with the Shah: 'I have been ready, so long as any have seemed to threaten mischief, to allow British troops to remain in Afghanistan, but your Majesty is well aware of my desire to withdraw them as soon as it may be safely done, and your Majesty's army shall be organised as to enable you fully to rely upon them for the maintenance of the legitimate Afghan monarchy.'[64]

This may have seemed a good plan in Simla, but in Kabul Shuja was all too aware that Macnaghten's strategy of diverting resources from the old tribal cavalry levies towards a professional standing infantry army removed his principal means of extending patronage to the chiefs. As far as the nobles were concerned, the Shah was duty-bound to give out money, land and estates to them in return for which they would provide cavalry. The system was certainly corrupt: 'ghost-payrolling' allowed the tribal leaders to claim financial allowances for much larger numbers of men than they actually raised. But it was nevertheless the glue that cemented the local and regional tribal leaders' loyalty to the regime at the centre. By aiming to create a modern, drilled force at the expense of the chieftains, Macnaghten was taking away Shah Shuja's only real opportunity to reward his nobility for their support and undermining the power and wealth of his most important followers.

Nevertheless, Macnaghten insisted on driving the reforms through, maintaining that the benefits and savings would outweigh the risks involved. Payments to the chiefs duly fell by a quarter, from 1.3 million rupees in 1839 to one million two years later, with the bulk of the cuts falling on the eastern Ghilzai tribes who controlled and policed the vital passes between Kabul and the Khyber. To make matters worse, the chiefs had naturally hoped that the wealthy Firangis would actually increase their allowances rather than reduce them. These high expectations increased their